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United Born and Bred

‘For the first time, it was my relationship with the club that was slipping away.’

Turkey were fantastic at the 2002 World Cup. Their passing, their movement, their edge. They play the right way and it makes them a great team to watch. For pure soccer, their two matches against Brazil, in the group and, then, in the semi-final, were the best of the summer. They came back from Japan and South Korea supposedly the third best team in the world. And, of course, we’d pulled them out of the hat for the Euro 2004 qualifiers. From the moment the draw was made, the England–Turkey games were always going to be the ones to decide who’d qualify from Group 7. And here we were, April 2 2003, after dropping points at home to Macedonia earlier in the season, knowing we had to get a result against Turkey at the Stadium of Light to give ourselves a decent chance of finishing top—especially with our last qualifier being the away game in Istanbul at the end of October.

Although I think we need to have a national stadium for England games and FA Cup Finals, I’ve really enjoyed playing international soccer at different club grounds around the country. It’s given people who otherwise would never have made the trip down to Wembley the chance to see England close up and I’d say the relationship between the fans and the players is better because of it. It feels like club loyalties get pushed to one side on these days and supporters get behind the team as a whole. It seems a long time ago now that England supporters would boo United players when their names were announced in the line up. For pressure games, it’s helped us to have a passionate crowd close up to the field, cheering us on. We were all looking forward to playing Turkey at the Stadium of Light: the atmosphere there is as intense as at any ground in England.